

THE STATE OF ONLINE BUSINESSES

What TrustMRR's **1,000** verified companies reveal about building sustainable revenue

Every number here is pulled from TrustMRR's dataset of 1,000 companies, straight from live payment processors — not self-reported decks. We ignored the individual companies and went looking for the patterns that separate durable revenue from noise.

\$133.7M

Verified trailing-12-month revenue across the cohort

\$3,068

Median 12-month revenue — the typical business is small

80%

Carry live recurring revenue through a payment API

The factors behind the insights

Financials, demand, model and market — joined on one row per company.

01

Verified revenue

30-day, 3-month, 12-month and lifetime, read from the processor

02

Recurring base

MRR, MRR growth and active subscription counts

03

Traffic

30-day visitors and revenue earned per visitor

04

Business model

B2B / B2C, target persona, value proposition

05

Pricing

Free, freemium, subscription, credits, in-app, contact-sales

06

Payment rails

Stripe, RevenueCat, Paddle, Polar, Lemon Squeezy and others

07

Category & geography

23 categories across 40+ countries

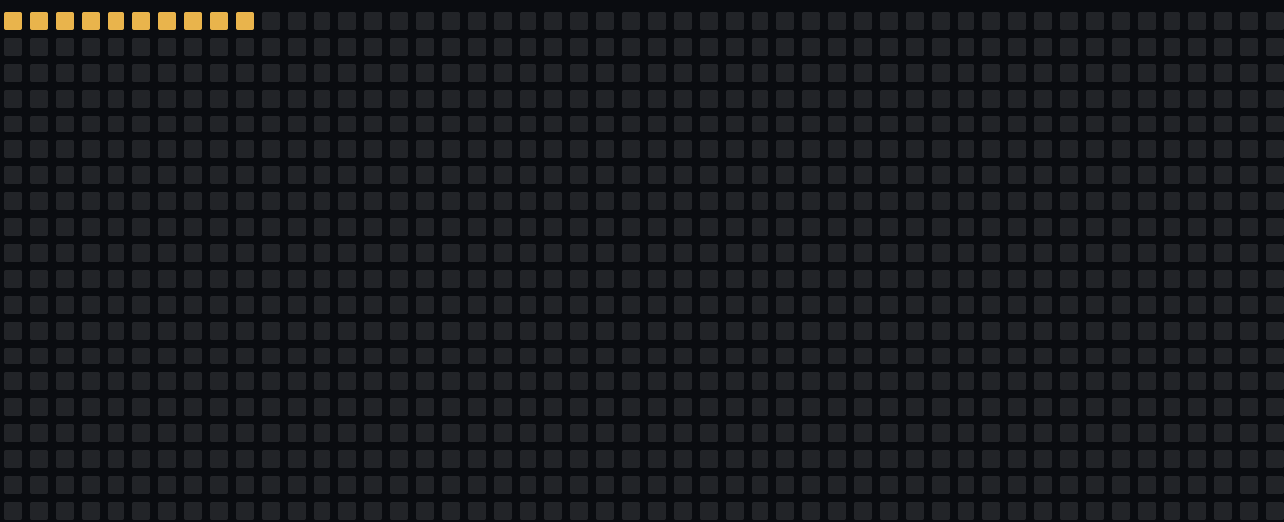
08

Acquisition signal

Asking price and revenue multiple for 262 listed businesses

Ten companies own half the ecosystem

Revenue is not distributed — it is concentrated. The top 1% of businesses captured 50.6% of all verified revenue; the top 10% captured 84.7%.



Each square is one business. The ten lit squares earn as much as the other 990 combined.

CATEGORY MEDIAN • 12-MONTH REVENUE

Education		\$14.3k
93% recurring · smallest crowd		
Content Creation		\$13.7k
highest revenue per visitor		
Marketing		\$10.0k
\$53 median ARPU		
Social Media		\$9.0k
AI		\$4.3k
27% of companies, 24% of revenue		
SaaS		\$2.3k
Productivity		\$350
most crowded, least monetised		

AI is the crowd, not the outlier. It contributes revenue exactly in proportion to how many people are building in it — while Education and Marketing quietly earn 3x the median on a fraction of the entrants.

Paying customers predict revenue. Attention does not.

MEDIAN 12-MONTH REVENUE BY ARPU QUARTILE

\$58.9k



Top ARPU quartile

Median 33 subscribers

\$1.6k

Bottom ARPU quartile

Median 40 subscribers

38x

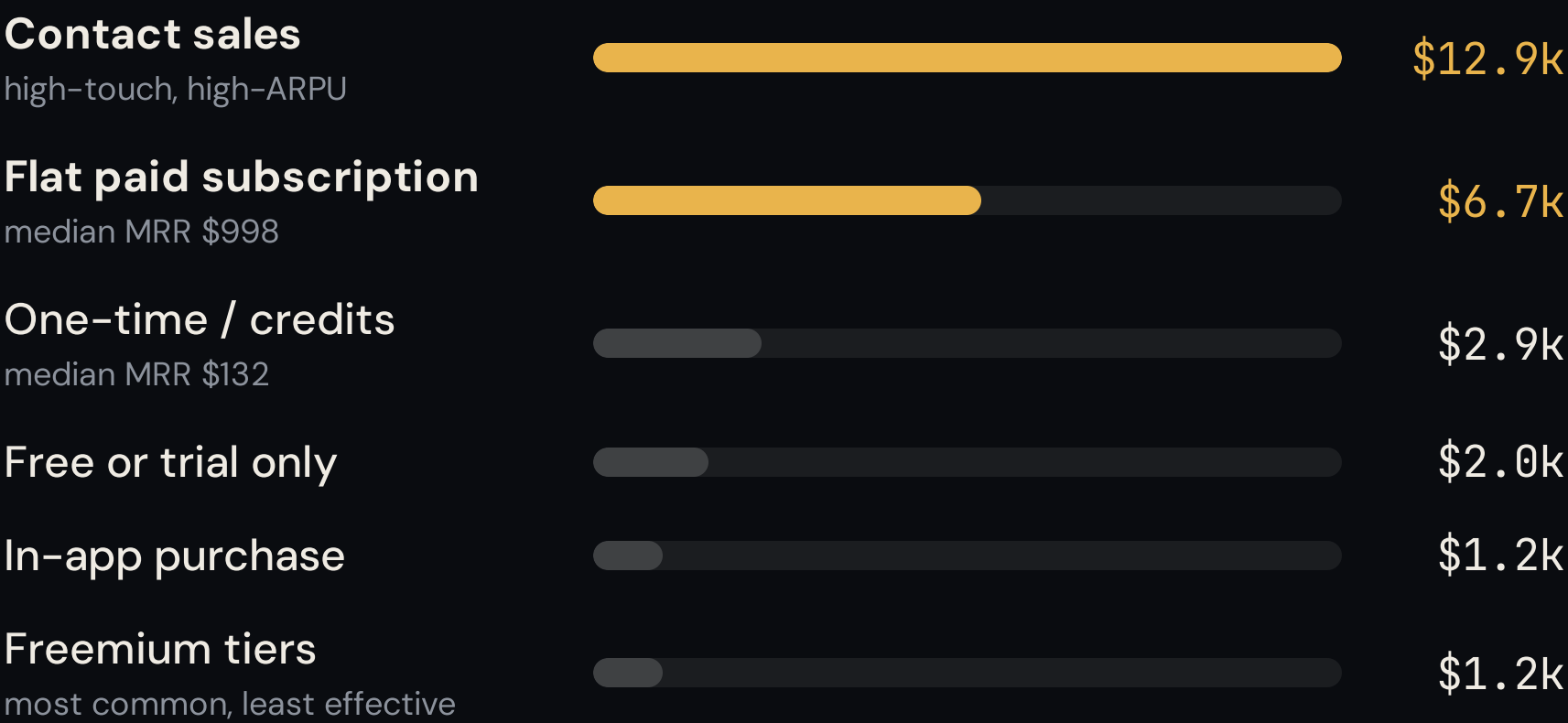
Revenue gap between the top and bottom ARPU quartile — on similar subscriber counts

More subscribers did not mean more revenue.
Price, not headcount, is the multiplier.

Revenue per visitor *falls* as traffic grows. Audience is a cost centre until it is priced.

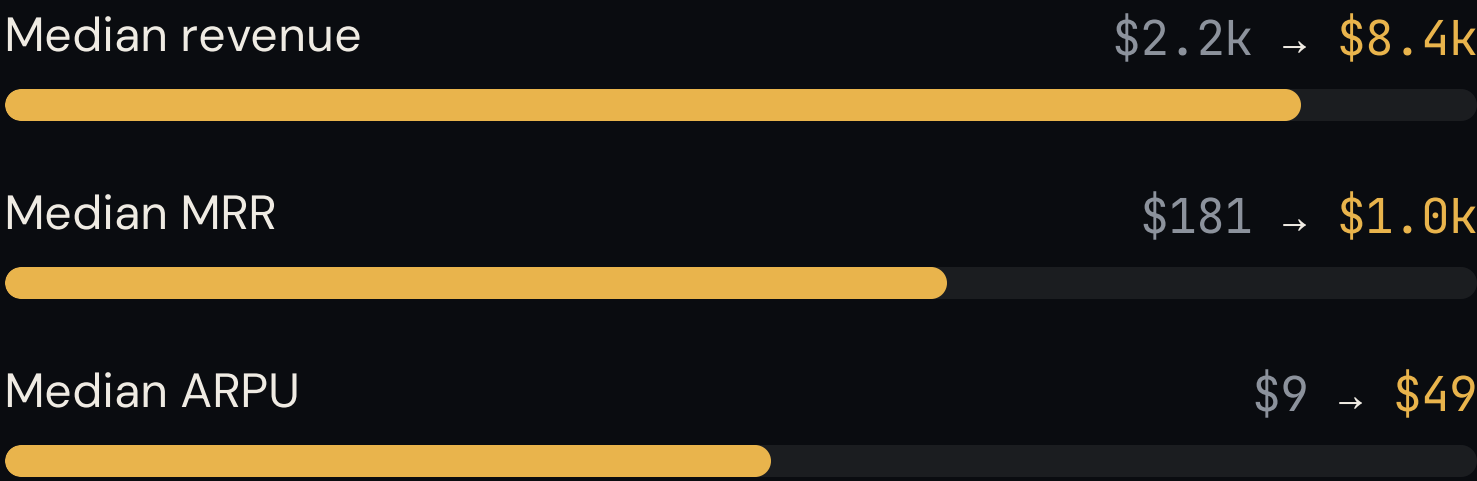
Winners charge deliberately — and sell to businesses

MEDIAN 12-MONTH REVENUE BY PRICING MODEL



Freemium is the default choice and the worst-performing one: 5.6x less revenue than a plain paid plan. Free tiers convert attention into cost, not cash — unless the paid tier is priced for a business buyer.

B2B VS B2C

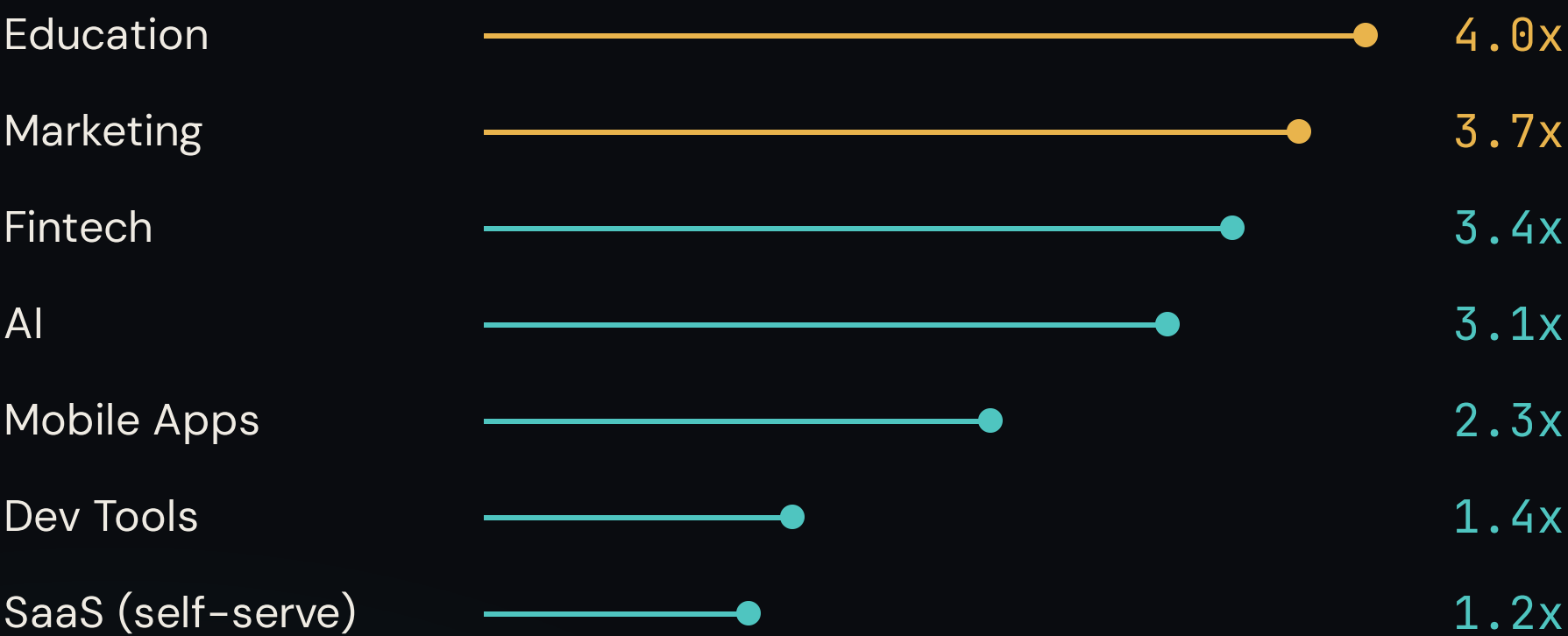


B2B businesses earn 3.8x more on the same subscriber counts. The difference is willingness to pay, not audience size.

Payment rails: Stripe is 64% of the cohort but 84% of the top 100 earners — serious revenue converges on billing built for invoicing and tax.

The market pays for recurring revenue — and nothing else

262 businesses are listed for sale. The median asks 2.3x trailing revenue.



Median revenue multiple among listed businesses, categories with 5+ listings.

Size buys nothing. Multiples sit between 2.1x and 3.0x from \$1k to \$3M of revenue: buyers price predictability, not scale.

The mispricing: self-serve SaaS and Dev Tools trade at 1.2–1.4x despite the highest revenue per visitor in the dataset — technical buyers underwrite them like software projects, not cash flows.

Five findings that contradict the founder folklore

01 $r = 0.04$

Followers are not a business

X following has essentially zero linear relationship with revenue. Several \$1M+ businesses have fewer than 100 followers.

02 55 customers

\$10.5M from a rounding error

The third-largest business in the dataset serves 55 active subscriptions. Enterprise contracts beat volume, decisively.

03 39.5%

Most 'startups' never clear \$1k

395 of 1,000 verified businesses earned under \$1,000 in a year. Building is easy now; charging still is not.

04 34%

Growth is the exception

Only a third of businesses grew revenue over the last 30 days — but among those above \$10k, it rises to 48%. Scale stabilises.

05 \$12.3k vs \$98

Geography is a 125x spread

US median revenue is \$12.3k; India's 59 businesses have a median of \$98. Same tools, radically different pricing power.

Five different questions. One answer: revenue comes from what you charge, not from who is watching.

The successful internet business is small, recurring and expensive

Five traits recur across every high-performing cohort in the data.

01	Recurring by default	_____	Businesses with live MRR earn a median of \$7,790 a year. Those without earn \$0.51.
02	Priced for a business buyer	_____	Median ARPU of \$49 in B2B versus \$9 in B2C — the same product, a different buyer.
03	Small, expensive audiences	_____	Top-quartile ARPU businesses hold fewer subscribers than the bottom quartile and earn 38x more.
04	A named niche	_____	Education, Marketing and Analytics — narrow categories with clear personas — beat generalist AI and Productivity on median revenue.
05	Owned demand, not rented attention	_____	Domain authority correlates with revenue ($p = 0.55$); social following does not ($p = 0.20$).

ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Growth gets attention. Recurring revenue gets bought.

Across TrustMRR's 1,000 verified companies, nothing predicted durable revenue — or a real valuation — as reliably as a customer who pays again next month.

- 01 Charge on day one. A free tier without a priced business buyer behind it is a 5.6x revenue penalty.
- 02 Optimise revenue per customer before revenue per visitor. Traffic scales cost; price scales margin.
- 03 Sell to businesses, or sell to consumers who behave like businesses.
- 04 Recurring revenue is the only thing acquirers actually underwrite.
- 05 Pick a niche narrow enough to name your buyer. The crowded categories are the poorest ones.

| Build for the second payment, not the first click.